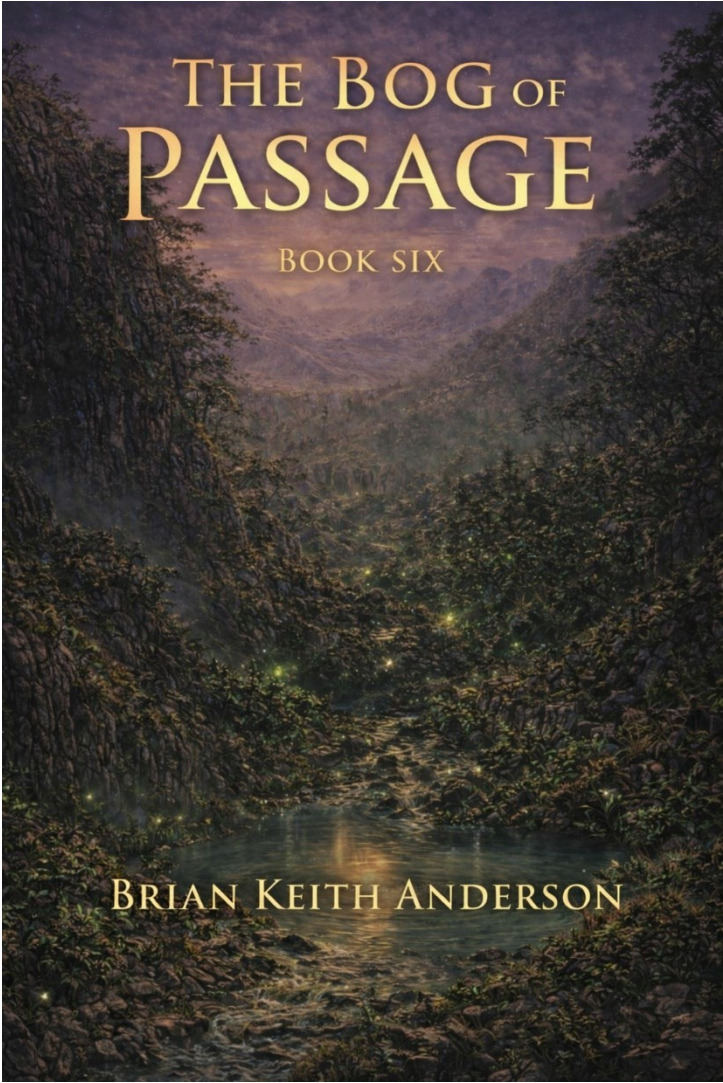


The background of the cover is a rich, atmospheric illustration. It depicts a deep, misty valley with a river winding through its center. The river's surface reflects the ambient light and the surrounding greenery. The banks are covered in dense, dark foliage, with several small, glowing green lights scattered throughout, suggesting magical or enchanted elements. In the distance, more forested hills are visible under a soft, hazy sky. The overall color palette is dominated by deep greens, browns, and a touch of purple in the upper atmosphere, creating a sense of mystery and depth.

# THE BOG OF PASSAGE

BOOK SIX

BRIAN KEITH ANDERSON

# THE SEVEN BOGS OF MARS

The Bog of Passage

Book Six

by

B.K. Anderson

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# Dedication

For those who are ready to  
cross.

# THE SEVEN BOGS OF MARS

Book One — The Seven Bogs of Mars

Book Two — The Bog of Patience

Book Three — The Bog of Silence

Book Four — The Bog of Movement

Book Five — The Bog of Restraint

Book Six — The Bog of Passage

Book Seven — The Bog of

Interconnection

Book Eight — The Seven Hearts

# Chapter One — The Bog of Passage

The ground did not wait for them.

It had already begun.

Asa felt it before he saw it.

Not movement—not like the last bog.

Not stillness—not like the one before.

This was something else.

Something that did not remain in place  
long enough to be named.

He stopped.

Not because he meant to.

But because the ground beneath him no longer felt like something that could be stood upon without thought.

It was not unstable.

It was... shifting.

Saxifraga did not stop beside him.

She stepped forward.

And the ground moved with her.

It did not open.

It did not break.

It simply changed.

As though the path ahead had not existed  
until she placed her foot upon it.

Asa watched.

Then looked down.

Where he stood—

the surface beneath him was no longer the  
same as it had been a moment before.

“You feel it,” she said.

It was not a question.



“It isn’t holding,” Asa said quietly.

“No,” Saxifraga answered.

“It was never meant to.”

Ahead, the land did not stretch.

It unfolded.

Not outward.

But through.

Asa took a step.

And the ground accepted it.

Not as something placed upon it—

but as something that had always been  
part of its becoming.

He paused again.

Not from fear.

But from the understanding that there  
would be no standing still here.

Behind him—

there was no clear path.

Only the memory of where he had been.

Ahead—

there was no fixed direction.

Only what would appear when he chose  
to move.

“This is not a place,” Asa said.

“No,” Saxifraga replied.

“It is not.”

She turned, not to guide him—

but to see if he would follow.

Asa looked once more at the ground  
beneath him.

It did not ask.

It did not resist.

It did not wait.

It simply became.

And for the first time—

he understood that crossing did not begin  
with the path.

It began with the step.

He moved.

And the Bog of Passage opened.

The first step did not settle.

It did not anchor.

Asa felt it shift beneath him—not away,  
not unstable—

but as though the ground itself adjusted to  
his presence.

Not supporting him.

Becoming with him.

He took another step.

This time more slowly.

Watching.

The surface ahead formed just before his  
foot touched it.

Not growing from the ground—

but appearing, as if it had always existed  
just beyond where he could see.

Behind him, the place he had stood  
moments before no longer remained.

Not erased.

Not gone.

Simply no longer needed.

Asa turned his head slightly, trying to  
follow the shape of where he had come  
from.

But there was no path to trace.

No line to follow back.

Only a quiet understanding:

There was no return through something  
that did not remain.

Saxifraga continued forward, her  
movement unbroken.

She did not hesitate.

Did not test the ground.

She moved as though she had already  
accepted what the bog was.

Asa watched her for a moment longer.

Then followed.

The air changed as they moved.

Not colder.

Not warmer.

But thinner in a way that did not take

breath—

only certainty.

He noticed it then.

The absence.



There was no resistance here.

No place that refused him.

No edge to push against.

No boundary to overcome.

And because of that—

there was nothing to measure himself  
against.

He stopped again.

Not from uncertainty. But because he did  
not yet understand how to continue  
without something to work against.

In the other bogs, there had always been something:

- stillness to learn
- silence to hear
- movement to follow
- restraint to hold

Here—

there was nothing to hold.

Nothing to fix.

Nothing to guide him except the act of moving itself.

“You are waiting,” Saxifraga said quietly.

Asa looked toward her.

“I don’t know what I’m waiting for.”

“That is why it does not form,” she  
replied.

He looked down again.

The ground beneath him remained—

but it did not extend.

Not until—

He shifted his weight forward.

Then it appeared.

Not as a path.

But as a continuation.

Asa exhaled slowly.

“It only exists when I move.”

Saxifraga did not answer immediately.

She watched him.

Then nodded once.

“It exists with you,” she said.

Asa stood still for a moment longer.

Feeling the absence of everything he had  
learned to rely on.

Then he stepped again.

This time without searching for what  
came next.

And the Bog of Passage responded—  
not by revealing the way—  
but by becoming it.

“ Thank you for reading sample”